

'Remember Me to God'**'TRUTHFUL,' 'BAD' — SISTERHOOD, AUTHOR, CRITIC EXCHANGE VIEWS**

By SANDY GOODMAN

MT. VERNON, N. Y. (NJP)—
"A very bad interpretation of Jewish life."

"Truthful. Anyone who can sit and tell you he or she hasn't met people like that just won't face reality."

THESE CONFLICTING opinions were voiced recently by women readers of "Remember Me to God," Myron S. Kaufmann's best-selling novel about a social climbing young Jew who tries to cast off his background and assimilate in the Gentile world.

The comments followed an author-meets-the-critic discussion between the 35-year-old Kaufmann and Harold U. Ribalow, critic and journalist, who in a number of reviews has been highly critical of the book's "unfriendly" depiction of Jewish characters.

The discussion, the first meeting between the soft-voiced young author and Ribalow, three years his senior, took place at Sinai Temple, Mt. Vernon, N. Y., in suburban Westchester County. It was sponsored by the temple's sisterhood.

'Stacking the Cards'

RIBALOW ACCUSED Kaufmann of "distorting" his portrayals, and "stacking the cards" against his Jewish characters, all of whom, he charged, are depicted unattractively.

"I am not asking for nice Jews," Ribalow asserted. "I know some are not nice."

"What I'm complaining about is that all Mr. Kaufmann's Jews are not nice."

In defending the novel, his first, which last week held down 10th place on The New York Times' bestseller list, Kaufmann said he was "surprised" that critics had found his characters so unappealing.

THE AUTHOR, who took eight years to write the novel while working as a reporter for the Associated Press, asserted he was "fond of my imaginary people." "If I wasn't," he added, "I could not have lived with them for so long."

The 640-page book deals with the Amsterdams, a Jewish family living in Boston during the early years of World War II. Adam and Bessie, the father and mother, have risen from poverty. Studying law at night, Adam has become a judge. Both parents are proud of their accomplishments and deeply conscious of both their

Jewishness and their Americanism.

'Decent, Respectable'

They have two children. Dorothy, their 16-year-old daughter, is a bright but awkward girl. Richard, the novel's protagonist, is a student at Harvard. He makes every effort to erase his Jewish upbringing and becomes a part of "Yankee" society.

KAUFMANN described the family as "decent and respectable, good-looking, attractive and honest."

"There is no character in the book I dislike," Mr. Kaufmann told his audience. He went on to say that his affinity for the characters extended to them as fictional creations, and not as real people.

In a book review, Mr. Ribalow had described the protagonist as comporting himself "as though he were the biggest 'heel' in contemporary American fiction."

Of his main character, Kaufmann said: "If he were flesh and blood I don't think I'd like him. He wouldn't like me and I don't like people who don't like me."

AFTER THE discussion, sisterhood members talked further among themselves about the novel.

Among those critical of the book was one woman who asked that she not be identified.

"I don't see how anyone could agree with Mr. Kaufmann's book or his views," she said.

"I've met a lot of Jews in my day but I've never run into any like Mr. Kaufmann depicts."

Mrs. Edward Popper of 19 Oakland Ave., Mt. Vernon, called the book "a very bad interpretation of Jewish life."

ALSO CRITICAL was Mrs. Pauline Levitan of 185 Hillcrest Ave., Mt. Vernon. "There are people such as the one depicted," she said. But there should have been one Jewish character, even a minor one, to set things straight.

"As it stands," she added, "there isn't one admirable character in the book. He should have one Jewish character who merits respect."

'Truthful Representation'

AMONG THOSE who sided with Kaufmann was Mrs. Roselle Roseman of 1225 Midland Ave., Bronxville, herself a former Bostonian.

"I wouldn't say the characters were any worse than people you meet on the outside," she said. "They were nice people."

"And this is a truthful interpretation of Jewish life. I have heard many a Jew, usually among the more cultured ones, say: 'I'd like to be a Gentile for a little while and see what it's

like not to be excluded from a lot of places.'"

"Anyone who can sit and tell you he or she hasn't met people like that just won't face reality," Mrs. Roseman concluded.

Also with Kaufmann was Mrs. Robert Dvoren of 24 Sunset Dr., Yonkers. "I don't feel he paints his characters in an unflattering way," she said. "As individuals, I don't think they're better or worse than our next door neighbors."

"I have great compassion for them. I can feel the problem the mother and father have of transmitting a love of Judaism to their children. Such problems do exist."

"I DON'T think he makes Jews look bad," declared Mrs. Richard

Fink of 234 Magnolia Ave., Mt. Vernon.

"I think he makes people look bad."

During the panel discussion Ribalow and Kaufmann disagreed on a number of specific points, chief among them the attractiveness or unattractiveness of several major characters.

ON THE MAIN character, Ribalow declared: "I can't stand him." In an earlier book review, he had said: "Nothing as distasteful as Richard Amsterdam has come to the public eye since the 'heroes' of Norman Katkov's equally bitter Jewish novels."

While admitting he might not like Richard if he were a flesh-and-blood person, Kaufmann expressed surprise that critics had found the character "no good."

"He is confused," Kaufmann

asserted, "but integrity he does have."

'Oy Vey' Character

Speaking about Bessie, Richard's mother, Ribalow called her an "Oy Vay character."

Kaufmann countered that his character did not use that expression, but rather simply, "Oy." "I don't find anything embarrassing or objectionable about a woman using that word," he said. "objectionable about a woman using that word," he said.

Dorothy, Richard's sister, was termed by Ribalow, "incredibly termed by Ribalow, 'incredibly

In answer, Kaufmann said that "if she were flesh and blood the man would be lucky who married her."

FEARS THAT the book presents Jews in an unfavorable light have not been supported since its publication, Kaufmann said.

He said that from letters and talks with Gentile readers he found that they "identify with the characters."

Ribalow answered that this view was "idealistic."

"We're only a little more than 10 years away from the time when six million Jews were killed," he said.

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Jewish Scientists Loom Large In Soviet Science Circles

WASHINGTON (NJP)—IT IS probable that Jewish scientists have made major contributions to the Russian development of the Sputnik and Muttnik satellites—and will continue to contribute heavily to other missile-age developments.

That conclusion stems from the latest figures, for Oct. 1, 1955, published in a Soviet handbook called "Cultural Construction In the USSR."

IT HAS BEEN estimated that one in each 70 persons in the Soviet Union is Jewish—but one in each nine Soviet scientists is a Jew, according to the pamphlet's official statistics.

Out of a total of 223,893 Soviet scientific researchers, 24,620 are Jewish.

Of the total, 144,285 are Russian, the remainder stemming from other ethnic groups. The second largest national group in the USSR, the Ukrainians, provided 21,762 of the total—fewer than are Jewish though the

Ukrainians outnumber Jews in Russia ten to one.

ACCORDING TO the Soviet handbook, there are more Jewish scientists in Russia than the combined number of those from White Russia, Nzbek, Kazakh, Georgia, Azerbaijan, Lithuania, Moldavia, Latvia, Kirghiz, Tadzhik, Armenia, Turkmenia and Estonia.

But there is some indication that the Soviet government more recently has sought to play down the Jewish contribution.

A Soviet publication called "The Attainments of Soviet Power for 40 Years In Figures," released for the 40th anniversary of the Bolshevik Revolution last November, used these same figures but deleted the figures on Jewish scientists.

THERE IS a possibility this omission was an oversight—but more than likely it indicates Soviet Russia did not wish to point up the role of Jewish scientists in Russian affairs.

WHAT'S DOING IN NEW YORK**COMING EVENTS**

Sunday, March 9, 8 p. m. Culmination of American Zionist fund campaign with cocktail party and reception. Jamaica Jewish center, 150-91 8th Rd., Jamaica.

Sunday, March 23, Long Island ZOA mid-winter conference. Congregation Beth Israel, Hempstead, L. I.

VICINITY OF NEW YORK

Sunday-Wednesday, March 16-19. Sirth annual convention of educators Assembly. Concord Hotel, Kiamisha Lake, N. Y.

LECTURES AND SYMPOSIUMS

Monday, March 10, 11 a. m. "Great Women in Jewish History: Jessie Samter-White Fire," lecture by Rabbi Herbert Parzen. Theodor Herzl institute, 250 W. 57th St.

Monday, March 10, 8:30 p. m., "Israel's Undergraduate: Programs and Problems of Israel's University Students," lecture by Bernard Cherrick, director general of the board of governors, Hebrew University. Theodor Herzl institute.

Tuesday, March 11, 8:30 p. m. "The Third Jewish Commonwealth," lecture by Cecil Roth, professor of History, Oxford, England. Theodor Herzl institute.

THEATER AND MUSIC

"Father Holds Court," new

Where To Find Your National Jewish Organization

Anti-Defamation League of B.B. 515 Madison Ave., New York 22, N. Y. Farband Labor Zionist Order, 45 E 17th St., N. Y. 4—OR 3-6500. Jewish National Fund, 42 East 69th St., New York 21—VA 6-3780. Kashruth Supervisors Union, 205 W 14th St. —AL 5-7330. National Community Relations Advisory Council, 55 West 42d St., LO 4-3450. Union of American Hebrew Congregations, 838 Fifth Ave. RE 7-8200. Union of Orthodox Jewish Congregations of America, 305 Broadway New York 7, N. Y. BE 3-2220.

comedy-drama by Israel Bashevis, presented by the Folksbiene, veteran Yiddish stage group. Radin Playhouse, 128 Stanton St.

"Sof Haolam," by Shamir, a Hebrew play presented by Habman Haktana. Saturday and Sunday evenings through April. Tickets at Herzliah Hebrew Teacher's institute, 314 W. 91st St., TR 7-4885. Admission, \$1.50-\$3.

Saturday, March 15, 8:30 p. m. "Habonim Annual Concert," Israel dance groups, choir, orchestra and dramatic performances. High School of Fashion

and Industries, 225 W. 24th St. Admission \$1.25, 75 cents for students.

ART

Art exhibit: Works of Abram Tromka. Showing includes oil paintings, etchings and drawings on Jewish themes. House of Living Judaism, 383 Fifth Ave., Feb. 1-Mar. 31.

Commemoration Exhibit: Works of Arthur Kaufman, commemorating his 70th birthday. Exhibits will include 31 oil paintings. Feb. 20-March 31. The Jewish museum of the Jewish Theological Seminary, 1109 Fifth Ave., corner 92d St.

National Antique Show: Included in this exhibition are a rare collection of Italian synagogue pieces from the 17th century and coins of Biblical times. March 10-16, Madison Square Garden.

Art Exhibit: Jewish Ceremonial Objects. A selection of Jewish religious and ceremonial objects from the Jewish Museum of the Jewish Theological Seminary of America. March 4-28. East River savings bank, Rockefeller plaza at 50th St.

Art Exhibit: Works of Ben-Zion. An exhibition of watercolors, gouaches and etchings. March 5-29. The Deitsch gallery, 51 E. 73d St.

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